features? First, their knowledge of Hinduism is simplistic, highly superficial and ritualistic. Second—and for precisely this reason—they are averse to dialogue, discussion and debate. Third, they have no compunction in resorting to violence to impose their views. Fourth, they are highly conservative and orthodox and supportive of the inequitable existing hierarchies in society. Fifth, they are deeply patriarchal, believing that women should accept their subordinate position and conform to stereotypical notions of so-called 'Hindu' values. Sixth, their dominant emotion is hatred of the 'other', others being defined as primarily Muslim, but also including all those who are not part of their smug circle of like-minded largely upper-caste brethren. Seventh, they want to glorify India's Hindu past, but their knowledge is farcical, consisting of a make-believe world of airplanes and cars, thereby devaluing the real achievements and refinements of ancient India. Eighth, they have scant regard for the rule of law, especially since they believe that they have the backing of the powers that be. Ninth, they have little problem in conflating religion with patriotism; only their type of Hindu can be patriotic, while the patriotism of all others is suspect. And tenth, they are particularly porous to false information as long as this buttresses their preconceived world view.

If these are the features of the practitioners of Hindutva, what can we expect them to do in the future? We must accept that with several state assembly elections on the anvil, and the national elections due in 2024, the BJP's electoral strategy will be to further religious polarisation, and accentuate Hindu-Muslim divide. For this, it will use a policy of both explicit encouragement to Hindu vigilante groups, and expedient denial, thereby hoping to reap political dividends while simultaneously distancing itself from the more lawless and outrageous actions.

THE BJP'S POLL STRATEGY WILL BE TO FURTHER RELIGIOUS POLARISATION, A POLICY OF BOTH EXPLICIT ENCOURAGEMENT TO HINDU VIGILANTE GROUPS, AND EXPEDIENT DENIAL...

We could, therefore, expect to see in 2022, the mosque in Mathura to come under attack, notwithstanding explicit legal provisions against such actions. A conjured siege mentality will be hyper ventilated through hate speeches, and 'hurt religious sentiments' will be the stick. There will be attacks against perceived derogations of Hindu dharma, as for instance witnessed in the brazenly illegal vandalisation of the shooting of the web series, *Ashram*. Stand-up comedians, who dare to speak truth to power, will continue to be pilloried. Women will be targeted for what they wear, who they meet, what they drink and eat and what kind of relationship they can have. Namaaz sites, already targeted in Gurgaon by Hindu vigilante groups in spite of administrative approvals, will come under further attack. Arbitrary injunctions for mandatory vegetarianism could proliferate, even if most Hindus eat meat. Claims will become louder that the Muslims are multiplying uncontrollably—when all official data points to the contrary. The recent attack on a church in Roorkee could become the template for more such hooliganism. Social media will be whipped up to target minorities and all those who refuse to accept this narrow, bigoted and exclusionist interpretation of Hinduism. Hyper patriotism will become an accessory to religious evangelism. Above all, there would be the pervasive and real threat of the use of force by organised lumpen elements against anyone not genuflecting before their writ. What is worse, law enforcing agencies will do very little, especially in BJP-ruled states, and—as Narottam Mishra, home minister of BJP-ruled Madhya Pradesh did in the case of the *Ashram* attack—statements will be made condoning such lawlessness.

For millennia, Hinduism has survived because it accommodates diversities and has the inherent ability for *shastrartha* or civilised discourse. Our foundational texts, the Upanishads, the Bhagwat Gita, the Brahman Sutras, are all dialogues. The eclecticism and inclusiveness of Hinduism is not its weakness but its strength. Hindutva, as the political arm of the BJP-RSS, wants to convert this remarkable faith to a series of ignorant, illiterate and distorted fiats. It is a danger that all real Hindus should face up to and defeat. ■

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